AA

League age 8 to 10 | Coach pitch to girls pitching | BLS division

The bridge from coach pitch to girls pitching. Girls take their first turns at pitcher and catcher, and a coach steps in so every batter still gets pitches to hit.

PURPOSE PROPOSAL

AA gets a girl ready for Minor A. It is the first time most girls play pitcher and catcher, with a coach there as a safety net. By the end of the season, every girl has batted against a girl pitching and every team has a handful of girls who can pitch to a batter.

AA is a learning division. Development and playing time come first.

GAME RULES PROPOSAL

BLS has no written softball AA rules yet. The proposal: use the same three phases as BLS baseball AA, so the coach steps out of pitching as the season goes on.

1. **Weeks 1 to 3.** No walks. At ball 4, a coach from the batting team finishes the count. No stealing while a coach pitches.
2. **Weeks 4 to 6.** Walks count, except with the bases loaded. Then the coach finishes the count.
3. **Week 7 on.** No coach pitching. Walks count.

- When a coach pitches, it is at game speed for this age, not lobbed. The girl in the pitcher spot stays near the circle and can field.
- Every girl plays at least 4 defensive innings, at least 1 inning in the infield and 1 in the outfield.
- No girl plays catcher more than 2 innings a game.
- 5 runs max per inning, except the last inning. No new inning after 1 hour 45 minutes.

WHAT LITTLE LEAGUE SAYS LITTLE LEAGUE

- Little League runs one Minor League Softball division for ages 5 to 11. Each local league splits it into levels by age and ability, such as coach pitch and player pitch. AA is the BLS step between coach pitch and player pitch.
- By local choice, some 8-year-olds can play up and some 9-year-olds can play down.
- The Minors field: 60 ft bases and a 35 ft pitching distance.
- Little League's own 8 to 10 tournament division uses an 11 inch ball, keeps runners on base until the pitch reaches the batter, and has no dropped third strike.
- Pitching limit for Minors and Majors: a girl can pitch in up to 12 innings a day. One pitch counts as an inning. If she pitches in 7 or more, she rests the next day.
- A pitcher who is taken out can't come back to pitch in the same game.
- Little League's stated aim is growing well-rounded kids, not building elite ballplayers.

FOCUS SKILLS PROPOSAL

1. **Pitcher (first time).** The windmill motion: grip, stride, arm circle, follow-through. The only goal is throwing strikes.
2. **Catcher (first time).** Putting the gear on, getting set behind the plate, catching pitches, throwing the ball back to the pitcher.
3. **Throwing and fielding (every girl).** Ground balls, an overhand throw to first, and knowing where the force out is.
4. **Hitting.** Swinging at strikes, first against a coach and then against a girl pitching.
5. **Running the bases.** Running through first, knowing when to run and when to stop.

BY THE END OF THE SEASON PROPOSAL

- Every girl has tried the pitching motion at practice.
- Every team has at least 4 girls who can pitch to a batter in a game.
- Every team has at least 3 girls who have played catcher in a game.
- Every girl can field a ground ball and throw it to first.
- Every girl has batted against a girl pitching.

NOT ENOUGH, TOO MUCH PROPOSAL

NOT ENOUGH

- Only one girl ever tries pitcher.
- Catchers never practice catching pitches with their gear on.
- Practice is mostly batting practice.
- Coaches lob the ball when they pitch in games.

TOO MUCH

- Asking a pitcher for speed before she can throw strikes.
- One girl pitching for most of a practice.
- More than 3 team practices a week.
- Coaching every pitch from the dugout during games.

A 90-MINUTE PRACTICE PROPOSAL

Warm up + throw 15	Stations 40	Team defense 20	Run 15

- **Stations:** pitchers and catchers working together (any girl who wants a turn), ground balls, hitting off a coach or a machine.
- **Team defense:** force outs and throws to first.
- **Running:** running through first, rounding a base, stopping.

COACH'S ROLE PROPOSAL

- Give every girl who wants it a turn at pitcher and catcher in practice.
- Plan who plays pitcher and catcher each game, and tell each girl why she plays where she plays.
- Tell parents at the first meeting that walks and errors are part of AA, and the season gets harder in steps on purpose.